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IN BRIEF



SKILLED DISPLAY — The Indian Air Force performing aerial manoeuvres during the 'Wings over Ganges' air show at Varanasi on Sunday.

18 held, ₹100 crore traced in Northeast drug raids

Simultaneous raids at 38 locations across Assam, Mizoram and Manipur smashed a "narco-hawala" cartel trafficking across the India–Myanmar–Bangladesh Death Triangle Corridor. The ED froze 1,424 bank accounts and attached ₹17.82 crore. **Pg 2**

Houthis strike Riyadh airport and naval base

Three military operations with dozens of ballistic missiles targeted King Khalid air base and a naval base at Jazan; the coalition says two were intercepted. **Pg 5**

A.P., Odisha on alert as deep depression forms

The Bay of Bengal system is to make landfall as a very severe cyclonic storm on October 28. Odisha has deployed 12 SDRF and seven NDRF battalions. **Pg 9**

Foreign investors pull out ₹48,056 crore

FPIs withdrew from Indian equities in October amid elevated crude prices and West Asia tensions. **Pg 7**

Ashoke Sen wins Oskar Klein Medal

The string theorist becomes the first Indian to receive the honour, awarded by Stockholm University and the Nobel Committee for Physics. **Pg 8**

LEAD · GS II GOVERNANCE & GS III INTERNAL SECURITY

Cybersecurity emerging as a critical concern, says PM

A country can be weakened by attacks on its economy, Modi says after opening the RBI's ₹169-crore data centre and Cybersecurity Training Institute in Bhubaneswar



BHUBANESWAR — The Prime Minister inaugurates the Reserve Bank of India's data centre and Cybersecurity Training Institute. PTI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday stressed the need to safeguard financial institutions against cybercriminals and cyberterrorists, warning that the changing nature of warfare had made cybersecurity a critical concern.

"We all know that wars today are not fought with weapons alone. A country can also be weakened by attacks on its economy," he said, adding that as India grows stronger economically, protecting the banking system from cybercriminals and cyberterrorists becomes equally essential.

"The nature of cyberthreats is changing. We cannot confront these emerging challenges with outdated systems, old training methods and obsolete tools. We need modern infrastructure as well as a skilled workforce," he said — the rationale for the new training institute.

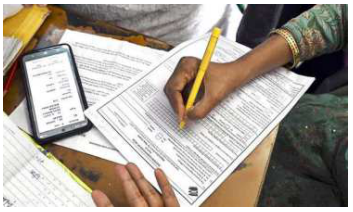
Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman also spoke. The Prime Minister praised Odisha's transition from a mineral-based economy to a microchip manufacturing hub.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Critical information infrastructure and the financial sector; CERT-In and the RBI's cyber resilience framework; cyber-warfare as a non-traditional security threat; financial inclusion as a governance claim.

GS II · REPRESENTATION OF THE PEOPLE

Officials filed a third of all Form 7s in Karnataka — none gave a reason

BENGALURU / CHENNAI



ELECTORAL ROLLS — Officials were instructed not to share ERONET login credentials. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

At least 61,059 of the roughly 1.82 lakh Form 7 applications seeking deletion of names from Karnataka's rolls during the claims-and-objections phase of the Special Intensive Revision were filed by election officials themselves — 33.6% of the total — with not a single application stating a reason for the deletion.

A reason is mandatory under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. Rule 17 provides that a claim or objection not lodged within the prescribed period, or not in the prescribed form and manner, "shall be rejected by the registration officer".

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Roll revision machinery and Forms 6/7/8; Rule 17 of the Registration of Electors Rules; the procedural-safeguard question now before the Supreme Court.

GS II · FEDERALISM & CONSTITUTIONAL OFFICES

Recommendation to remove KPSC chief sparks a row over Article 317

Former Kerala Governor is reported to have written to the President seeking dissolution of the State Public Service Commission

In an unprecedented move, former Kerala Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar has reportedly recommended to the President the removal of Kerala Public Service Commission chairperson M.R. Baiju over alleged irregularities in the recruitment body — a communication said to have been sent a week before he was relieved of his duties.

The constitutional provision is narrow. Under **Article 317**, the President may remove the chairperson or a member of a State Public Service Commission for misbehaviour only after the Supreme Court, on a reference made to it, holds an inquiry and recommends removal. The Communist Party of India (Marxist) called the move "unconstitutional", asking how a Governor could ask the President to dissolve the PSC when no allegation had been proven in court.

The Leader of the Opposition in the State Assembly said the recommendation was "unlawful, a violation of constitutional provisions and gross abuse of power", while the Bharatiya Janata Party argued that the move raised concerns about the role of Lok Bhavans and should not be read as shielding the accused.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Article 317 and the protected tenure of PSC members; the Governor's discretionary communications with the President; recruitment-body integrity and institutional autonomy. Pair this with Article 324(5) on the CEC for a clean comparison of removal procedures.

GS II · INTERNAL SECURITY

Congress seeks Manipur CM's resignation and fresh polls

Alleging a failure to contain renewed violence, the principal Opposition party demanded the Chief Minister's resignation, dissolution of the State Assembly and fresh elections, alongside a Union government intervention to initiate an inclusive peace process.

It said no armed group or individual attacking civilians should enjoy "political protection or immunity", and cited the killing of three Meitei civilians on October 19 and clashes in Kamjong district in which Kuki and Naga civilians were killed. Around 300 people have been killed since May 2023 and nearly 60,000 displaced, with about 24,000 yet to return home.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Ethnic conflict and the State's duty to protect; Article 356 debates; internally displaced persons and rehabilitation.

THE BIG STORY · ELECTORAL ROLLS

U.P. orders re-verification of every form filed through computer operators

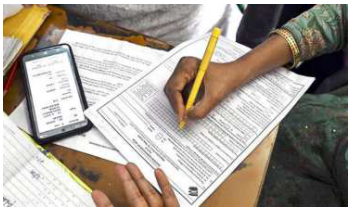
Chief Electoral Officer bars outsourced operators from feeding physical application forms; all entries since the SIR concluded on April 10 to be checked afresh

Amid controversy over errors found in the electoral rolls published after the Special Intensive Revision, the Chief Electoral Officer of Uttar Pradesh on Sunday ordered re-verification of all entries made by computer operators since the publication of the post-SIR final electoral rolls on April 10, and directed that all future digital applications be filed only by Booth Level Officers.

"Under no circumstances should the feeding of physical application forms be handled by computer assistants. It must also be ensured that all physical forms received are digitised exclusively by the BLO through the BLO App," an official statement said. Electoral Registration Officers must review all Form 6, Form 7 and Form 8 applications daily and ensure prompt disposal strictly as per rules.

All officials were strictly instructed not to share their ERONET login ID and password with anyone, and to conduct a mandatory verification of every Form 6, 7 and 8 entry fed by computer assistants since the conclusion of the SIR.

Officials were warned of action under **Section 32 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950**, which pertains to breach of official duty in connection with the preparation of electoral rolls.



RE-VERIFICATION — Every entry fed by a computer assistant since April 10 is to be checked afresh. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

WHY IT MATTERS — Section 32 of the RP Act, 1950; the BLO–ERO–CEO chain of responsibility; outsourcing of statutory functions and the integrity of the ERONET database. Read alongside the Karnataka Form 7 story on Page 1: both go to whether roll revision is auditable.

OPAQUE DELETIONS — KARNATAKA'S FORM 7S AT A GLANCE

CATEGORY OF FORM 7 FILINGS (SINCE AUG 24)	NUMBER	SHARE
Total Form 7s filed	1,81,509	100%
Filed in the name of the elector	1,12,514	62.0%
Filed by officials — none citing a reason	**61,059**	**33.6%**
Filed by third parties	7,936	4.4%

Districts where officials filed the most: B.B.M.P. South 10,374 · B.B.M.P. North 8,443 · Bengaluru Urban 8,102 · Kolar 3,392 · Chikkaballapur 3,330. Karnataka's final roll is scheduled for publication on October 27.

GS II · RIGHT TO PROTEST

Jamia protest intensifies amid heavy police deployment



NEW DELHI — Students were informally told to vacate the hostel on account of online classes and upcoming festivals. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

A day after attempts were made to forcibly remove protesting students, students gathered around the campus and tried to enter by climbing the gates. Classes were suspended, water facilities on the campus were cut off and no entry or exit was allowed, but students still gathered in large numbers.

The agitation seeks restoration of the students' union, dissolved after campus violence; elections were last held in 2006. Central Reserve Police Force and Delhi Police personnel guarding the entry gates were seen dispersing students trying to enter.

A first information report has been registered on charges of trespassing, defacement of property and confinement, against political leaders and students, under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

WHY IT MATTERS — Article 19(1)(a) and 19(1)(b) on campus; the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations on student union elections; university autonomy versus democratic participation.

GS I · HISTORIOGRAPHY

'Hindutva reading of Indian history is single and fixed'



Romila Thapar

Delivering a memorial lecture on "Historiography and Early Indian History", the historian said colonial historians fundamentally shaped the way Indian history came to be understood, reducing complex social and political processes to simplified religious narratives that continue to influence historical interpretations today.

She criticised the British historian James Mill's periodisation of Indian history into Hindu, Muslim and British periods, arguing that such categorisation imposed simplistic divisions on a far more complex experience, and that the tendency to read Indian history primarily through a religious lens was inherited from colonial scholarship.

"In this interpretation, the purpose of history is not to explain what happened in the past, but instead to construct statements of contemporary political views," she said — adding that such statements deny the centrality of secularism and democracy as essential components of the new nation.

WHY IT MATTERS — Schools of Indian historiography: colonial, nationalist, Marxist, subaltern; Mill's periodisation and its critique; a ready quotation for essay papers on history and nation-building.

GS II · INTER-STATE DISPUTES

Kotia: panchayat polls in villages claimed by two States

The Biju Janata Dal sought the Prime Minister's intervention in the decades-old dispute between Odisha and Andhra Pradesh over the Kotia cluster of villages, after Andhra Pradesh notified panchayat elections in three disputed villages for November 3.

The dispute is before the Supreme Court, and residents of these villages enjoy **dual voting rights in both States** — a standing illustration of an unresolved boundary question.

WHY IT MATTERS — Inter-State boundary disputes and Article 131; the Supreme Court's 2006 restraint on altering boundaries; dual enrolment as an electoral anomaly.

GS II · PARTY POLITICS

Kharge frames the SIR as a 'second war of Independence'



PATNA — The Congress president at an event marking the 139th birth anniversary of Bihar's first Chief Minister, Sri Krishna Singh. PTI

The Congress president alleged a nexus between the ruling party and the Election Commission, claiming that names were being deleted from voters' lists at the party's behest, and urged the people of Bihar to support a nationwide movement against the revision.

He said two Election Commissioners had written letters on 14 separate occasions raising objections regarding the CEC's intent to manipulate the voter rolls, and that their concerns went unheeded. The ruling party announced nationwide counter-protests over his remarks about the Prime Minister.

WHY IT MATTERS — The 2023 Act on appointment of the CEC and ECs; dissent within a multi-member constitutional body; electoral administration as a political battleground.

GS III · DRUG TRAFFICKING

₹100 crore and 18 arrests in the Northeast narco-hawala crackdown

Enforcement agencies conducted simultaneous raids at 38 locations across Assam, Mizoram and Manipur on October 23, leading to 18 arrests and the detection of ₹100 crore in hawala transactions linked to an international narco-cartel.

- Local carriers were hired by Myanmar-based organisers to move consignments.
- Payments were routed through 'hawala' accounts receiving drug proceeds from across the Northeast.
- Bank accounts in Champhai, Aizawl and Lawngtlai received drug money, settled with suppliers in Myanmar.
- The Enforcement Directorate froze 1,424 bank accounts, attached assets of about ₹17.82 crore and seized 500 detonators and ₹12 lakh in cash.
- A counter codenamed "Nuniang" in Churachandpur made 2,947 transfers involving ₹175.03 crore between 2024 and June 2026.

WHY IT MATTERS — The Golden Triangle and India's eastern border; PMLA and the ED's attachment powers; the drugs–terror–hawala nexus; the stated target of eradicating the drug network by December 31, 2029.

TEXT & CONTEXT · JUDICIAL CONDUCT

Where should judicial restraint begin?

A sitting judge's remarks on voter deletions have revived the debate over judicial propriety and comment on pending cases; his emphasis on voting rights aligns with existing rulings, but his statement against mass disenfranchisement raises questions about the limits of judicial speech



LETTER & SPIRIT — The Restatement of Values of Judicial Life bars judges from commenting on pending or likely judicial matters. GETTY IMAGES

Delivering a valedictory address at a moot court competition on October 4, Justice Ujjal Bhuyan said the right to vote was constitutional and integral to the basic structure. A process disenfranchising millions, he said, would be intrinsically arbitrary and violate **Articles 14 and 326**; Article 326 "cannot be tinkered with", and "no court can condone" mass disenfranchisement. Citing **Section 22 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950**, he stressed the need for notice and a hearing before deletion, except in the case of death.

A former Chief Justice of India objected that judicial propriety did not permit a sitting judge to comment on a sub judice matter. Former High Court judges expressed similar concerns.

What the Indian code requires. The starting point is the Restatement of Values of Judicial Life, adopted by the Full Court of the Supreme Court on May 7, 1997. Clause 8 says a judge shall neither enter public debate nor express views on political matters "or on matters which are pending or are likely to arise for judicial determination". Clause 1 requires conduct sustaining public faith in judicial impartiality. The Restatement carries no sanction of its own, but has been reproduced and relied upon in judicial decisions.

Did he state something new? On May 27, 2026, a Bench headed by the Chief Justice of India upheld the Bihar SIR in *Association for Democratic Reforms v Election Commission of India*. The court described the right to vote as constitutional, though neither absolute nor unregulated, and said Articles 325 and 326 require inclusion of eligible electors and exclusion of ineligible persons. **Rule 21A of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960** requires notice, inquiry, hearing and a reasoned determination before deletion.

Justice Bhuyan was therefore on established ground in describing voting as constitutional and stressing a hearing before deletion. The more debatable part was his proposition that a process disenfranchising millions would be intrinsically arbitrary and that no court could condone it — conditional language that did not decide whether a particular SIR produces that result.

Comparative standards. The commentary on the **Bangalore Principles of Judicial Conduct** recognises judicial freedom of expression on legal education, judicial independence and court administration. Principle 2.4 restrains comment that might reasonably affect a proceeding before, or capable of coming before, the judge; Principle 4.11 allows judges to write, lecture and teach on law. The U.S. Supreme Court's 2023 Code of Conduct permits the same, while asking Justices to refrain from commenting on the merits of a pending or impending matter. The distinction is between explaining an issue and appearing to answer it.

WHY IT MATTERS — Judicial propriety and the Restatement of Values of Judicial Life, 1997; the Bangalore Principles; Articles 14, 325, 326; Rule 21A and Section 22 of the RP Act. A rich GS II and GS IV crossover on institutional ethics.

THE GIST

- The Restatement of Values of Judicial Life bars judges from commenting on pending or likely judicial matters.
- Comparative standards allow judges to discuss legal issues but caution against remarks that could affect pending proceedings.
- The judge's record includes both strict and claimant-protective rulings, showing why public speeches cannot predict judicial outcomes.

GS II · RIGHT TO ASSEMBLY

Lessons on the right to assembly

OPINION · THULASI K. RAJ, ADVOCATE, SUPREME COURT

Article 19(1)(a) guarantees free speech and **Article 19(1)(b)** the right to assemble peaceably without arms. Fundamental rights operate as limits on state action; any restriction must be subject to Article 19(3), which permits a law in the interests of sovereignty, integrity or public order, imposing reasonable restrictions.

Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 — invoked in the capital immediately before the protests — is held to be inherently problematic, as it gives wide discretion to the executive to direct the removal of persons to prevent the disturbance of public tranquillity, among other grounds.

In *Himmat Lal v Commissioner of Police* (1972), the Supreme Court held that reasonable regulation of assembly differs from arbitrary exclusion: while reasonable time, place and manner restrictions may be imposed, the State "cannot constitutionally close both its streets and its parks entirely to public meetings". In *Babulal Parate v State of Maharashtra* (1961) the court declined to interfere with the predecessor provision, but said it is 'attracted only in emergencies'.

Designating protest sites matters because a meaningful right to assembly requires public places that are accessible and available. Moving protests to distant areas renders their purpose meaningless.

WHY IT MATTERS — Article 19(1)(b) and 19(3); Section 163 BNSS; *Himmat Lal* and *Babulal Parate*; the designated-protest-site question. Prime GS II mains material.

GS II · MEDIA & REGULATION

The case for a national media council

Recent protests have rekindled the debate over who has the right to be recognised as a journalist. Under the **Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020**, a working journalist is a person whose principal avocation is journalism and who is employed in a newspaper, electronic media or digital media — a definition excluding those in managerial or administrative capacity.

Accreditation by the PIB (for central coverage) and the DIP (for the Delhi State government) recognises working journalists, freelance journalists, camerapersons and technicians, and gives access to designated official sources. But eligibility criteria carry quotas depending on circulation, subscribers, licence, and unique visitors for digital news publishers — leaving journalists in unrecognised organisations outside the system.

The proposal: just as the Bar Council of India exists for lawyers and the Institute of Chartered Accountants for chartered accountants, a statutory media council could recognise all working journalists and mandate a degree or diploma in journalism for a licence.

WHY IT MATTERS — Press freedom and professional regulation; the Press Council of India's limits; a counter-argument on licensing as a restriction under Article 19(2).

WEST ASIA · THE LEAD

‘War, or no war, our policies remain unchanged’, says Iran

Tehran says it is already thinking about the post-war period; the remarks come as Washington signals plans for a new military operation



MURAL MESSAGING — Motorcyclists drive past a billboard depicting a Persian legendary hero hitting U.S. aircraft carriers in Tehran. AP

Iran’s Foreign Minister said on Sunday that a potential resumption of war with Israel and the United States would not change his country’s positions. “Recently, there has been talk of a new war, but I am already thinking about the post-war period. Whether there is war or not, our policies remain the same.”

Iran has claimed control over the **Strait of Hormuz** since the outbreak of the war that began on February 28, and has regularly targeted vessels that attempt crossing without its authorisation. In response, the United States has maintained a naval counter-blockade on Iranian ports.

“The current war has changed everything. We must accept that new realities are taking hold. Shipping routes through the Strait of Hormuz will no longer be the same, and the management of the strait will no longer be the same,” the Foreign Minister said.

Energy stress. Parliament’s Speaker called for a campaign to cut gas usage by at least 10% as winter approaches, with officials anticipating shortages. Though a major producer, Iran has suffered shortages of natural gas exacerbated by war.

WHY IT MATTERS — The Strait of Hormuz as a global energy chokepoint; freedom of navigation under UNCLOS; blockade in international law; the direct impact on India’s crude import basket and shipping insurance costs.

LATIN AMERICA

Brazil votes in a nail-biting presidential run-off



PUBLIC VOICE — Voters arrive by boat at a polling station in the Lago do Catalao community in Iranduba, Amazonas state. AFP

Brazilians voted in a run-off that will determine whether the United States significantly expands its growing influence in Latin America. Polls ahead of the vote showed the two candidates, who need more than 50% of the vote to become Brazil’s next leader, in a neck-and-neck race.

The election pits the veteran incumbent against an ally of the U.S. President and the son of an imprisoned former President. It is the final electoral battle for the incumbent, who turns 81 on October 27 and who bested his rival by more than 2.2 million votes in the first round.

Four years ago the incumbent won by the narrowest margin since the country’s return to democracy in 1985. Voting in Brazil is conducted electronically and results are usually available within hours.

WHY IT MATTERS — Great-power competition in Latin America; BRICS cohesion if leadership changes; electronic voting as a comparative model.

NEIGHBOURHOOD

‘Maldives President could stir up an anti-India campaign again’



Abdulla Shahid, former Foreign Minister of the Maldives. SUHASINI HAIDAR

Days after the Maldives President visited Pakistan for a bilateral visit that yielded many agreements, the former Foreign Minister accused him of moving in an “anti-India” direction, and said he would try to make India the issue again ahead of the 2028 presidential elections because he had not been able to deliver on promises.

The two sides announced agreements in defence and maritime security, combating illicit trafficking and narcotics, information technology, cybersecurity and AI, and agreed to start direct flights between Malé and Islamabad. The Maldivian President also called for the revival of **SAARC**, on hold since 2016 when India pulled out of the Islamabad summit.

India’s position, as stated by the External Affairs Ministry, is that it wants a “close watch” on such developments. The ‘India Out’ campaign of 2023 had led to the withdrawal of 89 Indian military personnel, replaced with civilian personnel in June 2024, after which relations improved.

WHY IT MATTERS — Neighbourhood First and the Indian Ocean Region; SAARC’s paralysis versus BIMSTEC; China and Pakistan in India’s maritime neighbourhood; debt-swap diplomacy.

ISRAEL & PALESTINE

West Bank operation displaces over 2,600



GAZA CITY — An Israeli drone strike on a university killed three people, local authorities said. AFP

The Israeli military pressed ahead with a large operation in the occupied West Bank that has displaced hundreds of Palestinians, in response to a gun attack that killed two Israeli soldiers. The operation in Hebron came as Israel enters the final days before an election largely seen as a referendum on the Prime Minister’s leadership and security policies.

The Army said most Palestinian workers’ permits would not be allowed to enter Israeli West Bank settlements, and crossings into Israel will remain closed until after Tuesday’s polls. It said it operated in more than 400 locations over the weekend and arrested 40 Palestinians it claimed were affiliated with militant groups. The Hebron municipality says the operation displaced more than 2,600 people.

WHY IT MATTERS — Occupation and international humanitarian law; collective punishment; the two-state question; India’s balancing position.

INDIA & THE UN

India slams Pakistan at the UN, calls its military the country's 'real ruler'

Responding at the General Assembly's Third Committee, India's Permanent Representative said Islamabad's "Form 47 government" could not override instructions from the country's real rulers, the Pakistani military. Form 47 is the official election document in Pakistan recording the provisional, consolidated results of a constituency; the February 2024 general elections were marred by allegations of rigging and irregularities.

WHY IT MATTERS — Civil–military relations in Pakistan; India's diplomatic posture in UN bodies on minority-rights questions.

INDIAN OCEAN · SANCTIONS

Iranian sailors treated in Sri Lanka as sanctions strand tankers



A Sri Lankan Navy vessel approaches an Iranian Navy vessel during a rescue operation off Colombo. REUTERS

Around 40 stranded Iranian sailors aboard U.S.-sanctioned oil tankers anchored just outside Sri Lanka's territorial waters received urgent medical treatment on the island. Colombo had earlier said it would not extend assistance to sanctioned vessels, emphasising that secondary sanctions were part of a broader directive and not specific to Sri Lanka. The Foreign Minister said the decision strictly protected sovereignty even as it was prepared to intervene on humanitarian grounds.

WHY IT MATTERS — Secondary sanctions and their extraterritorial reach; humanitarian exemptions; small-state manoeuvring in the Indian Ocean. Compare with India's own medicine-route dispute with Iran.

GS II · BILATERAL

India and Poland: new avenues, no conflict

Sixteen years after his last visit, Poland's Prime Minister travelled to Delhi and Bengaluru, two months ahead of the Indian Prime Minister's trip to Brussels to sign the India–EU Free Trade Agreement. Both sides agreed it was time to develop trade, currently worth just $6 billion, to double its size by 2030.

Poland has officially crossed the **$1 trillion (nominal GDP) milestone** and is the EU's sixth largest economy. A large part of Polish machinery and parts is exported to Germany, which in turn has a growing share of Indian imports; India could consider trilateral collaborations for manufacturing and mining technology. The two sides agreed to establish a "Defence Industry Dialogue" and explore a dialogue on counter-terrorism.

The friction point is trust: India's defence engagement with Russia, and Poland's defence ties with Pakistan. Poland is credited with training Pakistan's Air Force in its early years; a mutual defence cooperation agreement was signed in 2018.

WHY IT MATTERS — India–EU FTA timelines; Central Europe in India's foreign policy; the Global South and the Ukraine war; grain and seafarers' safety as negotiating planks.

EUROPE · IN BRIEF



PARIS — French groups called for demonstrations on October 31 and November 5 to maintain pressure on the government; 410,000 took part in Saturday's marches and 1,314 were arrested. REUTERS

Serbia votes as students seek to unseat the populist incumbent

Turnout was the highest in more than three decades at 64.89%, as a student-led movement culminating two years of protests — sparked by the 2024 collapse of a canopy at a railway station that killed 16 and was blamed on corruption — challenged the governing party.

U.K. PM calls for an 'honest discussion' on EU free movement

Britain's Prime Minister indicated he was open to readopting the bloc's free movement rules as part of a future relationship, saying the country should have an honest discussion about how immigration has changed since Brexit.

Venezuelan Opposition leader returns from exile

The Nobel Peace Prize winner returned home after nearly a year in exile — her first appearance since the U.S. military deposed the country's then-President in January.

Musk accuses Ukraine of using Starlink for 'killer' drone strikes

The tech executive accused Ukraine of violating Starlink's terms of service by using it for "drone strikes to kill people", saying the loophole was closed. Kyiv disputes the claim, saying drones operated via Starlink had a speed restriction of 70–90 km/h within Ukraine and did not work in Russia. **A private firm shaping the conduct of an inter-state war — a recurring GS III theme.**

25%
Hike in compensation for wildlife attack deaths and permanent disabilities announced by Kerala — from ₹14 lakh to ₹17.5 lakh.

922 kg
Adulterated food destroyed by the Delhi Food Safety Department during festive-season inspections.

1,314
People arrested across France in a second consecutive weekend of unrest over the cost of living.

392
Personnel under the scanner in Madhya Pradesh for alleged financial irregularities; 7 dismissed from service.

₹48,056 cr
Withdrawn by foreign investors from Indian equities in October so far, amid elevated crude prices.

GS III · DATA PROTECTION & HEALTH

India must train its clinical staff before erecting data shields

User data is routinely commoditised; passing a law and waiting for complaints will not suffice. As the DPDP Act comes into effect, the government must finance, build and sustain an ecosystem that lets every health worker comply



COMPLIANCE COSTS — The government should not expect every small hospital, diagnostic centre or primary health centre to independently purchase the same privacy tools. BERMIX STUDIO / UNSPLASH

The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 consists of **44 sections in nine chapters plus one Schedule**. The government notified its Rules on November 13, 2025. Provisions relating to consent managers take effect from **November 13, 2026**; the rest of the substantive obligations begin on **May 13, 2027**.

Why healthcare is unusually difficult. In healthcare, clinical consent and data consent are different things: a person agreeing to undergo a medical scan does not automatically mean they have agreed to every later use of that scan, however useful the hospital or doctors deem the data to be. The Act makes room for data-processing during emergencies and specific medico-legal and public health situations.

Under the Act, the patient is the **data principal** and the hospital — which decides why and how some information will be used — is the **data fiduciary**. External software, cloud and data-processing companies serve as the **data processor**.

Information rarely stays within the hospital: a cashless claim sends diagnoses and reports to an insurer or third-party administrator, while laboratories, radiology platforms, cloud vendors and telemedicine services create additional routes for the same record. Even low-cost WhatsApp-based workflows that became popular for convenience will have to be examined for compliance and security.

The cost of compliance. Hospital information systems need role-based access, facilities to encrypt or mask data, audit logs, backups, vendor contracts, breach response protocols, staff training, and a clearly identified person responsible for data governance. Designated fiduciaries must appoint a statutory data protection officer; smaller hospitals will need a privacy lead in practice. Failure to take reasonable safeguards can attract a penalty of up to **₹250 crore**.

No uniform training. India has legislated faster than it has trained the people who must make the law work. Medical education teaches confidentiality and ethics, but there is no uniform DPDP-oriented National Medical Commission curriculum spanning medicine, nursing, allied health, hospital administration and healthcare IT. The National Health Accounts 2022-23 estimated out-of-pocket expenses at **43.4%** of total health expenditure — so new compliance costs may well be passed to patients.

WHY IT MATTERS — DPDP Act architecture (data principal, fiduciary, processor, consent manager); the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission and the Unified Health Interface; the capacity-versus-legislation gap. A strong GS II/III mains answer on implementation deficit.

GS III · CYBER SECURITY

Two new PHP flaws put websites and their users at risk

The fixes are available, but owners must update every affected system and check for signs of a breach

On October 21 the team behind PHP announced two serious security flaws. In simple terms, a hacker could use them to break into a website's server from far away, without needing physical access or a password.

PHP runs behind the scenes on a very large share of websites — online shops, blogs, news sites, membership sites and business tools. If something goes wrong in PHP itself, many websites can be affected at once, especially on cheap shared hosting.

What went wrong. Both flaws are mistakes in memory tidy-up. The first is a problem with running out of space: when PHP runs low on memory it can end up handling half-finished data badly while cleaning up, which leaves the shelves in a mess — **memory corruption**. The second is a stale note: PHP keeps a note pointing to a shelf that has already been cleared, then tries to use what it thinks is there and finds something else entirely — a **use-after-free**.

A skilled attacker can sometimes use these messes to sneak in their own instructions and make the server run them — **remote code execution**. The flaws sit deep inside PHP, so they can be triggered before a website's own protections, such as login checks, get a chance to step in.

WHY IT MATTERS — Software supply-chain risk and open-source maintenance; responsible disclosure; CERT-In advisories. Note the vocabulary: memory corruption, use-after-free, remote code execution.

GS III · SEMICONDUCTORS

Semiconductor summit to weigh chip geopolitics and the talent gap

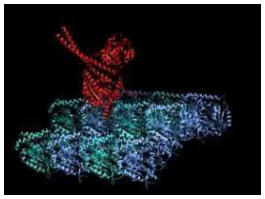
A summit tomorrow will examine global semiconductor rivalries, U.S.–China tensions, export controls and supply-chain disruptions affecting India's technological and economic strategies. Panels will cover "Chips for the Next Battlefield: Semiconductors, AI and the Future of Defence" — on AI-enabled defence systems and next-generation military technologies — and "From Design to Fab: Can India Build a Complete Semiconductor Ecosystem?", covering research, development, chip design, fabrication and packaging.

A third session addresses the widening demand for skilled engineers, chip designers, researchers and specialised professionals.

WHY IT MATTERS — India Semiconductor Mission; OSAT versus fabrication; export-control regimes; chip talent as a strategic constraint.

WHAT IS IT?

Molecular machines



The protein kinesin (red) attaches to and moves along microtubules (blue-green). CC BY-SA

A molecular machine is a combination of molecules that converts energy into motion to perform specific tasks. Nature makes abundant use of them: the protein **kinesin** transports minerals inside the body's cells by moving on microscopic tracks, and **myosin** helps muscles contract.

Artificial molecular machines date to the 1980s. In 1983 the French chemist Jean-Pierre Sauvage and his team reported a way to connect two ring-shaped molecules the same way an axle connects the wheels of a car. Eight years on, Fraser Stoddart built a structure in which a molecular ring could move along an axle. Together with the Dutch chemist Ben Feringa, who led a team that built a molecular motor driven by light, Sauvage and Stoddart won the chemistry Nobel Prize in 2026 for their work.

They are finicky: at the scale of a molecule, random heat constantly jostles the structures, rendering their movements unpredictable. But on October 22 researchers reported in *Nature* a corkscrew-shaped molecule that, suspended between two electrodes, could cycle through a series of states as current flowed one way and in reverse.

WHY IT MATTERS — Nobel Prizes in chemistry; nanotechnology and molecular motors; targeted drug delivery as an application.

GS III · DIGITAL POLICING

Cyber commandos lead the fight against hoaxes and crypto frauds



The IFSO unit helps field officers solve cybercrime cases across the National Capital Region.

Delhi Police has eight cyber commandos, deployed by a case's technical requirements and the expertise needed. In the event of a ransomware attack on a government system, the **Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C)** identifies a suitable commando to assist the investigation alongside the State police, which remains the first responder.

The Cyber Commando programme was inaugurated in 2024, with 300 personnel trained in its first batch. The selected officers underwent six months of residential training at eight centres, including the National Forensic Sciences University and Indian Institutes of Technology.

Work spans tracing cryptocurrency transactions in 'digital arrest' scams, where stolen amounts are quickly converted into cryptocurrency and transferred abroad; flagging manipulated videos and misleading posts; and mapping digital trails where suspects use VPNs or the Tor network to conceal their IP address.

WHY IT MATTERS — I4C and the cybercrime architecture; digital-arrest frauds; deepfakes and platform takedown requests; capacity-building in policing.

GS III · SCIENCE

Ashoke Sen wins the Oskar Klein Medal



Ashoke Sen is the first Indian to win the award. R. RAVINDRAN

The theoretical physicist has been awarded the 2026 Oskar Klein Medal — becoming the first Indian laureate — conferred by Stockholm University and the Nobel Committee for Physics of the Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences, for significant contributions to theoretical physics.

His career has focused on **string theory**, the attempt by physicists to describe matter and nature's fundamental forces, including gravity, within a single framework called **quantum gravity**. Physics is currently split across two frameworks — quantum physics and relativity — and string theory offers ways to reconcile them, though it has been unable to make predictions testable with today's technologies.

In the 1980s he helped establish how the equations describing hypothetical strings moving through space relate to the equations describing physical fields — an idea called **S-duality**. He has also done important work on black holes, developing mathematical methods to make sense of a black hole's microscopic states in a way that could account for its observable, macroscopic characteristics. In 1999 he proposed three related ideas, the **Sen conjectures**.

He has received the S.S. Bhatnagar Prize (1994), the Infosys Prize (2009), the Breakthrough Prize in Fundamental Physics (2012), the Dirac Medal (2014), and the Padma Shri (2001) and Padma Bhushan (2013). The Medal was launched in 1988 to honour the Swedish physicist Oskar Klein (1894–1977), whose work with Theodor Kaluza explored whether electromagnetism and gravity could be described in a common framework by introducing an extra dimension of space — **Kaluza–Klein theory**.

WHY IT MATTERS — Awards and Indian scientists (prelims staple); string theory, quantum gravity, S-duality, Kaluza–Klein theory as terms; ICTS Bengaluru, TIFR, HRI Prayagraj as institutions.

DATA POINT · GS I SOCIETY

Free bus travel has given women more mobility

Time Use Survey data from 2019 and 2024 show that women's travel went up in all four States that offer free bus rides to women — and the gain over men was largest where the scheme has run longest

Between 2021 and 2024, four States made travel in ordinary government buses free for women. Punjab and Tamil Nadu introduced the scheme in 2021, Karnataka followed in June 2023 and Telangana in December 2023. The National Statistics Office has conducted two all-India Time Use Surveys, one through 2019 and another through 2024, in which about 4.5 lakh persons in each round reported how they spent every half hour of a day.

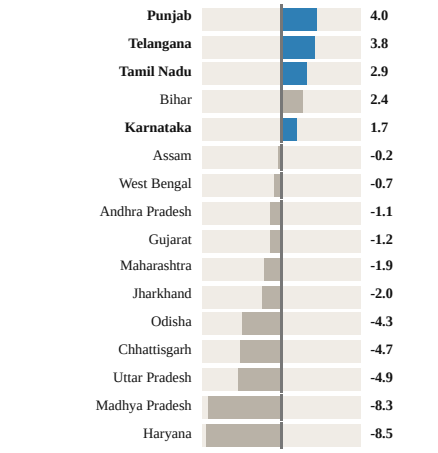
In the four States, the share of women aged 15–59 who made at least one trip on the survey day went up from **38.7% in 2019 to 45.3% in 2024**, an increase of 6.6 percentage points, while for men the increase was 3.7 points. In the 12 other large States studied, it was the other way round: women's travel went up by 4.4 points and men's by 7.6.

More reason to step out. The share of women who travelled for paid work went up by 2.3 points in the free-bus States and by 1.2 points in the others. The biggest change was in trips made for **care** — dropping children at school or taking a family member to hospital — which nearly tripled in the free-bus States. Trips for social, religious and leisure purposes also increased.

The rise was sharpest around **9 a.m.** (+1.6 pp) and **6 p.m.** (+1.2 pp), but there was also an increase in late-morning and afternoon travel, which are not usual office hours and are more likely to be the time for care and household work.

A caution: free buses make it easier for women to step out of their homes, but getting a job also depends on other things — whether there is work nearby, whether childcare is available, and whether the journey is safe.

CHART 1 · WOMEN'S GAIN OVER MEN, 2019 TO 2024 (PERCENTAGE POINTS)



Blue = free-bus States. In Telangana the share of women increased by 10.9 pp while that of men went up by 7.1 pp — a difference of 3.8 pp.

TABLE 1 · WOMEN AGED 15–59 MAKING AT LEAST ONE TRIP (%)

STATE	FREE BUS SINCE	2019	2024	ΔW	ΔM
Telangana	Dec 2023	43.7	54.6	10.9	7.1
Tamil Nadu	2021	43.8	50.6	6.7	3.8
Karnataka	Jun 2023	36.6	41.5	5.0	3.2
Punjab	Apr 2021	22.5	26.6	4.1	0.1
All free-bus States	—	**38.7**	**45.3**	**6.6**	**3.7**
Andhra Pradesh	Aug 2025*	40.8	41.6	0.8	1.9
Other States	None	23.9	28.3	4.4	7.6

*Andhra Pradesh's scheme began after the 2024 survey ended. Source: NSO Time Use Surveys 2019 and 2024.

WHY IT MATTERS — Female labour force participation and the mobility constraint; Time Use Surveys as a data source; unpaid care work; welfare schemes and the 'freebies' debate. An unusually well-evidenced example for any answer on women's economic participation.

GS I · GEOGRAPHY & CLIMATE

Wicked surprise: the northeast monsoon is more unpredictable

As India recovers from a monsoon-deficit year, there is both hope and trepidation about the 'other monsoon'. While contributing only about **a quarter of India's annual rainfall**, it is largely focused on the southeast peninsular regions of Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, coastal Andhra Pradesh, Rayalaseema, south interior Karnataka and Kerala.

The southwest monsoon, influenced by a strengthening El Niño, has already left its desiccating mark. Rainfall from June to September was **759.4 mm against 868.6 mm, a 12.6% deficit — the driest in 11 years**. This has hit *kharif* sowing and is reflected in food inflation.

The IMD has said the northeast monsoon, spanning October to December, would likely be 'normal', meaning in line with a 50-year average and within a 12% error window. Most parts of the country are expected to receive below-normal rainfall, except some areas of northwest India and southern parts of peninsular India.

But the wider error window for the northeast monsoon makes it far less precise than forecasts for the southwest monsoon. December 1, 2015 saw Chennai deluged by its heaviest rainfall in 24 hours in over a century; at least 500 lives were lost and 18 lakh people displaced. That year and the present are linked by a common thread: a powerful El Niño.

Associated with the heating up of the Central Pacific, El Niño is linked to the drying up of the southwest monsoon rains but also yoked — not always — with a vigorous northeast monsoon. In 2015, several El Niño years such as 1997 and 2009 have been associated with above-normal rainfall between October and December in Tamil Nadu, though 2002 and 1982 saw a poor northeast monsoon.

WHY IT MATTERS — Retreating monsoon mechanism; ENSO teleconnections and their limits; IMD forecast error windows; urban flooding preparedness. Note the honest caveat that El Niño deflects rain-bearing systems in unpredictable ways.

GS III · DISASTER MANAGEMENT

Deep depression to cross as a very severe cyclonic storm

The depression over eastcentral and adjoining southeast Bay of Bengal moved west-northwestwards at 5 kmph and intensified into a deep depression. It is very likely to move north-northwestwards and intensify into a severe cyclonic storm over westcentral Bay by Tuesday morning, with landfall expected on **October 28**.

Andhra Pradesh has deployed **12 battalions of the State Disaster Response Force and seven battalions of the NDRF**, and has requisitioned three more NDRF battalions in view of an impact greater than last year's severe cyclonic storm. People in the likely impact zones will be evacuated to shelters on or before October 27. Odisha deployed 24 ODRAF teams and six NDRF teams across five districts, and instructed eight Ministers, including two Deputy Chief Ministers, to station themselves in eight districts to supervise disaster management measures.

WHY IT MATTERS — IMD cyclone intensity scale; NDRF/SDRF/ODRAF architecture; pre-emptive evacuation and the zero-casualty model; political accountability in disaster response.

GS II · EDUCATION

The inverted faculty pyramid

A Parliamentary Standing Committee report tabled in March 2025 recorded faculty vacancy data as of January 31, 2025 across IITs, NITs, IIMs, IISERs and central universities. Of **18,940 sanctioned teaching posts**, **17.97% of assistant professor** posts were vacant, **38.28% of associate professor** posts and **56.18% of professor** posts. The vacancy rate more than triples between the entry rank and the seniormost rank.

Seen against global patterns this is unusual. In the U.S. and the U.K., attrition is concentrated at the early-career stage, where job insecurity, tenure pressure and low pay push people out; once a scholar reaches a senior rank, retention improves. In India the reverse is true: the system retains junior faculty reasonably well and loses its most senior people at a much higher rate.

The distinction matters because senior faculty supervise doctoral students, lead research groups, sit on academic and administrative committees that shape institutional policy, and mentor early-career colleagues on how to build a research programme, secure funding and navigate publishing. When a professorship remains vacant, these functions either do not happen or happen poorly, through informal and overstretched arrangements.

The gap compounds. Poorly supervised doctoral students become the next generation of faculty, trained to a lower standard than they would have been under adequate senior guidance. Weaker research leadership today reduces funded output tomorrow, which in turn makes vacant senior posts harder to fill. A second pattern compounds it: the growing use of contractual and ad hoc faculty positions to fill teaching gaps — fewer than 10% of these appointments are renewed into longer-term roles.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Higher education governance and NEP 2020 implementation; research capacity; the distinction between a staffing shortfall and a structural reproduction problem. Strong GS II answer material.

GS II · CHILD RIGHTS & WELFARE

Aftercare plan for youth leaving care homes

The Delhi government is set to introduce individual plans for every child exiting Child Care Institutions at 18, based on their circumstances, requirements and rehabilitation needs. Under the proposed 'Aftercare Scheme for Young Persons', eligible beneficiaries will receive up to **₹2 lakh for higher education and ₹60,000 for vocational training**. A database of individuals eligible for aftercare will be maintained and they will be recommended to various departments for internships, contractual roles or outsourced employment opportunities.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015 and the aftercare mandate; transition from institutional care; vulnerability of care leavers.

GS II · CHILD RIGHTS

Child rights panel seeks inquiry report in two weeks

The Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights issued notices to the Directorate of Education, a school principal and the police over the death of a 17-year-old Class 12 student found with severe burns at a government school. A commission member said the case hinted at a lack of accessible, quality mental health services in schools.

The commission raised concerns about student safety, questioning how the student managed to bring an inflammable substance into the school premises without being noticed, and said the incident was a violation of child rights on account of negligence of public servants. A three-page note and a water bottle containing petrol were recovered from the spot.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — NCPCR and State commissions under the CPCR Act, 2005; school safety guidelines; student mental health as a governance gap.

GS III · GIG & PLATFORM WORK

Maid to order: quick-help apps reshape domestic work

Since 2025, applications have entered the domestic work market, and existing players have expanded their services to include house help on demand. These allow customers to book a worker — almost exclusively women — for an hour.

Rating-based pay. Workers report no weekly offs and that lunch time is decided by a supervisor; star ratings work both ways, and a worker reported badly by a customer may appear on another's list as a "potential customer". Sick days result in docking of pay. One worker with six bookings a day, each up to two hours, is paid ₹25,000 a month if she gets all five stars; at four stars the pay is halved.

No safety net. Domestic-work app-based workers are not currently eligible for social security under any Maharashtra government scheme. Organisers say the apps have made these women 'partners' rather than workers, putting them under the 'self-employed' category — and that when registration on the State domestic worker portal requires an employer's signature, most customers refuse to sign.

Parliament passed the **Social Security Code, 2020**, which provides for the unorganised workforce, including gig and platform workers. Efforts are under way to register these women on the **e-Shram** portal in the national database of unorganised workers, which can facilitate access to eligible social-security schemes.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Gig and platform workers under the Social Security Code, 2020; e-Shram; algorithmic management and rating systems as a new form of labour control; the employee-versus-partner classification question.

IN BRIEF

First snowfall at Yamunotri and Kedarnath

The season's first snowfall brought cheer to pilgrims as the Char Dham Yatra entered its final phase, with a surge in pilgrim arrivals offering relief to local businesses that depend on the pilgrimage.

Army trains 50 Delhi Civil Defence volunteers

A three-day programme at 60 Infantry Brigade, Palam, covered drone threats, air-raid preparedness, fire safety, search and rescue, casualty management, cyber hygiene and emergency communication — to strengthen response and civil–military coordination.

Medical rooms for first aid in 1,086 Delhi schools

At a cost of ₹48.87 crore, each school will have a trained health worker such as an Auxiliary Nurse Midwife to address immediate health needs and provide adolescent health support, first aid and ORS. Diagnostic services and prescription medicines will not be provided.

GS III · MARKETS & REGULATION

SEBI lets equity funds hold gold, silver and InvITs

The Securities and Exchange Board of India has allowed equity funds to invest up to **35% of their residual portfolio** in non-equity investments. Large-cap active funds must invest not less than 80% in large-cap stocks, leaving room to wander into mid-cap and small-cap space; typically they have used the residual allocation (not more than 20%) for mid-caps.

The new regulation allows these funds to invest in gold ETFs, silver ETFs and **Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs)**. The rationale is that gold and silver could perform well when equity markets decline sharply, stabilising portfolios in volatile periods.

The investor's problem. Investors may already hold gold and silver ETFs directly as part of a satellite portfolio. If an equity fund also takes exposure to those metals, direct exposure plus indirect exposure through the active equity fund can skew the intended asset allocation. Index funds and equity ETFs, as passive products, must mirror their benchmark — so they will continue to deliver the intended equity exposure.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Mutual fund categorisation norms; asset allocation and diversification; InvITs as an infrastructure financing instrument; SEBI's regulatory role.

THE MAIN EDITORIAL ARGUMENT

From Jantar Mantar to ‘Dilli Chalo’: protest challenges power

Disparate protest movements are converging over shared concerns about democracy and accountability — but mobilisation becomes political change only when parties can translate it

Over the past few months, three distinct streams of dissent have emerged in India: a party-led agitation, actions by left-wing student organisations, and campaigns spearheaded by the principal Opposition and its bloc. Although these streams have largely evolved independently, their paths have increasingly converged around shared concerns about democracy, dissent, citizens’ rights and the fairness of the political and electoral process.

Dissent finds new voices. The first phase unfolded in June and July, focusing on education reform, the national entrance test paper leaks and demands for the then Education Minister’s resignation. The agitation drew large numbers of young people onto the streets, where they articulated their grievances through a distinctive blend of humour, creativity and youthful energy. This indicated that dissatisfaction with the ruling establishment extended well beyond the established Opposition parties, with the political disaffection of this constituency having been seriously underestimated.

On Gandhi Jayanti, Opposition parties, student groups and civil society activists took to the streets demanding the Chief Election Commissioner’s resignation over the Special Intensive Revision. Mobile Internet services were suspended around Jantar Mantar, gates at a number of Metro stations were closed, and more than 700 protesters were detained in the vicinity. A massive deployment of police and paramilitary forces brought much of the capital to a near standstill, effectively preventing the gathering from taking place.

The contrast was telling. While the later Opposition-led march showed a party’s capacity to draw large crowds onto the streets, the earlier calls brought youth discontent into sharper public focus. The Jantar Mantar uprising created new political space outside parties. Its most significant contribution was to break the climate of fear.

The issue of electoral fairness. At the heart of this public upsurge is a widening struggle over the sanctity of the vote, a cornerstone of democracy. By early September 2026, the exercise had resulted in the exclusion of **13.37 crore names** from draft electoral rolls across 30 States and Union Territories — equivalent to **14.1% of the pre-SIR electorate** — raising concerns about the possible disenfranchisement of eligible voters. The central question is whether the revision is transparent, verifiable and subject to adequate safeguards against arbitrary exclusion, particularly given concerns about the reliability of the procedures and centralised software used to remove names.

The protest, accompanied by a petition to the Supreme Court seeking an investigation, an audit of voter deletions, safeguards against arbitrary exclusion and suspension of the process, underscored a convergence between mass participation, Opposition mobilisation and legal action. The petition also puts the judiciary to the test, challenging it to protect constitutional rights through judicial review rather than allow executive decisions to evade scrutiny.

The Commission’s independence had already been questioned following the enactment of the **2023 Act on the appointment, conditions of service and term of office of the CEC and other Election Commissioners**, which excluded the Chief Justice of India from the panel appointing Election Commissioners and provided immunity from civil and criminal proceedings for acts undertaken in the discharge of official duties. Reports of disagreements among the Election Commissioners over unilateral decisions have further fuelled questions.

The vulnerability of power. Unable to offer political solutions, the government has instead deployed its coercive powers to quell dissent, particularly among the youth. Such measures cannot obscure deeper concerns over the erosion of the constitutionally guaranteed right to vote. By resorting to repression, the government has exposed the limits of its political dominance and sharpened the disconnect between the young and the ruling party, as well as eroded trust in the institutions it controls.

The challenge now is to convert this heightened public scrutiny into a sustained political check. The central question is whether this wave of public dissent over the electoral process can connect with wider popular resentments over the education system, unemployment and rising prices, and translate them into political change.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Pressure groups and social movements; the 2023 Act on CEC appointment; judicial review as a check on executive action; democratic backsliding literature. Directly usable in GS II answers on the role of civil society and on electoral reform.

“Moving protests to distant areas renders the purpose of protests meaningless.”

ON DESIGNATING PROTEST SITES — SEE PAGE 4

GS II · INDIA–U.S.

U.S. immigration restrictions may outlast the present administration

The administration’s attempt to impose a **$100,000 payment requirement on certain new H-1B petitions**, changes to visa renewal procedures, the introduction of a **wage-weighted selection system**, and suspensions of the Program Electronic Review Management process are cases in point, disproportionately impacting Indian immigrants and firms.

It is tempting to read these as a product of one administration alone, but they reflect deeper political interests likely to survive post-incumbency. Indian nationals account for **70% of H-1B visa approvals**, with one-fifth going to employees of Indian-origin companies. As the bipartisan focus on immigration reform continues, the issue is likely to sustain as a friction point in India–U.S. relations.

Both parties, same direction. Some 75% of Democrats see skilled immigration as good for the U.S., compared with 54% of Republicans; Democrats have pushed for easing F-1 student visa requirements. But prominent Democratic Senators, as well as progressive Independents, have also pushed for bills seeking H-1B reforms, and the party’s labour wing views the programme as a potential threat to domestic labour protections and workers’ rights.

The business divide. There are three broad categories: the **random lottery** system in place until 2026, which benefited outsourcing firms and start-ups; the **wage-weighted lottery** (February 2026), which infers wage levels based on experience, job role and location, dividing visa quotas into four categories; and the **actual wage weighted** model, supported by U.S.-based industries, which could dilute advantages enjoyed by outsourcing firms.

With over **54% of India’s software services exports** going to the U.S., this is a major challenge for Indian IT outsourcing. But the reform could help AI firms secure top international talent, and the suspension of eight firms — including major outsourcing companies and large technology firms — from green card sponsorship raises the cost of hiring foreign workers generally.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Diaspora and skilled migration in India’s external economic relations; services trade; the structural-versus-personality reading of foreign policy change.

FROM THE ARCHIVES

A hundred years ago — October 26, 1926: The Indian civil service

In accordance with the recommendation of the Lee Commission, direct recruits to the Indian Civil Service were then being selected in equal numbers from Europeans and Indians. For the purpose of calculation, the London examination of one year and the Allahabad examination and nominations of the next year were taken together as forming one year. In 1925–26, the London examination and nominations of 1925 actually recruited 20 Europeans and 22 Indians; adjusted in 1926–27 by recruiting 29 Europeans and 27 Indians. The London examination of 1926 yielded 19 Europeans and 11 Indians, leaving 16 Indians to be recruited in 1927.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — The Lee Commission (1924) and Indianisation of the services; a direct modern-history prelims and mains fact.

Prelims Pointers & Mains Practice — from today's edition

CONSTITUTIONAL & LEGAL PROVISIONS IN TODAY'S NEWS

PROVISION	WHAT IT SAYS — AND WHERE IT APPEARED
Article 317	The President may remove a State Public Service Commission chairperson or member for misbehaviour *only* after a Supreme Court inquiry on a reference and its recommendation. *(KPSC row, Pg 1)*
Articles 14 & 326	Equality before law; elections on the basis of adult suffrage. A judge held Article 326 "cannot be tinkered with". *(Pg 4)*
Articles 325 & 326	Require inclusion of eligible electors and exclusion of ineligible persons — the SIR ruling of May 27, 2026. *(Pg 4)*
Article 19(1)(a), 19(1)(b), 19(3)	Free speech; peaceable assembly without arms; reasonable restrictions in the interests of sovereignty, integrity or public order. *(Pg 4)*
Article 131	Original jurisdiction of the Supreme Court in disputes between States — relevant to the Kotia cluster. *(Pg 3)*
Section 22, RP Act 1950	Deletion of entries from electoral rolls; requires notice and hearing except on death. *(Pg 4)*
Section 32, RP Act 1950	Breach of official duty in connection with preparation of electoral rolls — warning issued to U.P. officials. *(Pg 2)*
Rule 17, Registration of Electors Rules, 1960	A claim or objection not in the prescribed form and manner *shall be rejected.* *(Pg 1)*
Rule 21A, same Rules	Requires notice, inquiry, hearing and a reasoned determination before deletion. *(Pg 4)*
Section 163, BNSS 2023	Successor to the old Section 144; power to issue orders to prevent disturbance of public tranquillity. *(Pg 4)*
CEC & Other ECs Act, 2023	Excluded the CJI from the appointment panel; gave immunity for acts in discharge of official duties. *(Pg 11)*
DPDP Act, 2023	44 sections, nine chapters, one Schedule. Consent-manager provisions from 13 Nov 2026; substantive obligations from 13 May 2027. Penalty up to ₹250 crore. *(Pg 7)*
Social Security Code, 2020	Covers unorganised, gig and platform workers; linked to the e-Shram database. *(Pg 10)*
Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020	Defines a "working journalist". *(Pg 4)*
JJ Act, 2015	Aftercare for young persons leaving Child Care Institutions at 18. *(Pg 10)*

CASES & CODES WORTH A LINE

- **Himmat Lal v Commissioner of Police (1972)** — the State cannot constitutionally close both its streets and its parks entirely to public meetings.
- **Babulal Parate v State of Maharashtra (1961)** — upheld the predecessor of Section 163, but said it is attracted only in emergencies.
- **Association for Democratic Reforms v ECI (27 May 2026)** — upheld the Bihar SIR; right to vote constitutional but neither absolute nor unregulated.
- **Restatement of Values of Judicial Life (7 May 1997)** — Clause 8 bars public comment on matters pending or likely to arise for judicial determination.
- **Bangalore Principles of Judicial Conduct** — Principle 2.4 restrains comment affecting a proceeding; Principle 4.11 permits writing, lecturing and teaching on law.
- **Lee Commission (1924)** — equal recruitment of Europeans and Indians to the ICS.

TERMS, BODIES & NUMBERS

- **ERONET** — the ECI's electoral roll management platform; **BLO App** for digitising forms.
- **Forms 6, 7, 8** — inclusion, deletion/objection, and correction/shifting respectively.
- **I4C** — Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre; Cyber Commando programme launched 2024.
- **InvIT** — Infrastructure Investment Trust; now permitted in equity funds' residual portfolio (up to 35%).
- **Time Use Survey** — NSO; rounds in 2019 and 2024, ~4.5 lakh persons each.
- **S-duality; Kaluza–Klein theory; Sen conjectures** — Oskar Klein Medal 2026.
- **Kinesin and myosin** — natural molecular machines; chemistry Nobel 2026 for artificial ones.
- **Memory corruption, use-after-free, remote code execution** — the PHP vulnerability vocabulary.
- **Form 47** — Pakistan's provisional consolidated constituency result document.
- **SAARC** — summits on hold since 2016; revival raised by the Maldives.
- **13.37 crore** names excluded from draft rolls — 14.1% of the pre-SIR electorate.
- **Monsoon 2026** — 759.4 mm against a normal of 868.6 mm; a 12.6% deficit, driest in 11 years.
- **Faculty vacancies** — 17.97% assistant, 38.28% associate, 56.18% professor, of 18,940 sanctioned posts.

Mains Practice

1. "A revision of electoral rolls that cannot be audited is not a revision but a redefinition of the electorate." Examine in the light of recent developments in roll revision across States. *(GS II, 250 words)*
2. Judicial speech can enrich constitutional conversation, but the lecture hall should not sound like a courtroom deciding a case before the parties are heard. Critically discuss. *(GS II / GS IV, 250 words)*
3. A right to assemble that may only be exercised where the State finds it convenient is a right in name alone. Comment with reference to the designation of protest sites. *(GS II, 150 words)*
4. India has legislated on data protection faster than it has trained the people who must make the law work. Examine this claim in the context of the healthcare sector. *(GS II / III, 250 words)*
5. Free bus travel for women is a mobility intervention, not an employment intervention — and that is precisely why it works. Evaluate using recent Time Use Survey evidence. *(GS I, 250 words)*
6. The vacancy rate in Indian higher education triples between the entry rank and the seniormost rank. Explain why this inversion is a structural problem rather than a staffing shortfall. *(GS II, 150 words)*
7. When an algorithm sets the pay, the rating and the roster, the question of who the employer is becomes a constitutional one. Discuss in the context of platform-based domestic work. *(GS III, 250 words)*
8. Energy chokepoints have always shaped Indian foreign policy; what has changed is that the chokepoint can now be closed by a party India has no leverage over. Elaborate. *(Essay)*



BIG SHOT — Waves crash against a lighthouse at Newhaven Harbour during Storm Austen in Britain. A low-pressure front brought 179 km/hr winds and heavy rain across Europe, with over three lakh homes losing power. REUTERS

A CLOSING NOTE

Every item in this edition was selected from a single day's newspaper on one test: does it touch the UPSC syllabus? Sport, racing, classifieds, tenders, advertisements, crime briefs, obituaries of non-syllabus figures, the crossword, the Sudoku and the daily quiz have all been removed. What remains has been re-written in brief, grouped by General Studies paper, and annotated with the syllabus link. Photographs and data are reproduced from the source edition for study use.

A UPSC-oriented digest. All items summarised in brief from the Delhi edition of The Hindu, 26 October 2026; please consult the original newspaper for full reports. Not affiliated with The Hindu or with any examination authority.